

THE NATURE
OF A
GOSPEL CHURCH

by

John Church

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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE NATURE
OF A GOSPEL CHURCH ***

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THE NATURE **OF A** **GOSPEL CHURCH:**

*A CONFESSION OF EVANGELICAL
PRINCIPLES:*

AND

THE MEMBERS' COVENANT.

Intended for the Use of

The Church of Christ.

BY J. CHURCH,
Minister of the Gospel, Obelisk Chapel.

EXODUS xxv, 40. Look that thou make all things according to the Pattern shewed thee in the Mount.

JUDE. Contend earnestly for the Faith once delivered to the Saints.

1 COR. i, 10. That ye be perfectly joined together in the same mind, and in the same judgment.

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THE NATURE OF A GOSPEL CHURCH, &c.

EPH. V. 23. CHRIST is the Head of the Church.

ACTS vii, 28. This is he that was in the Church in the Wilderness.

REV. ii, 27. All the Churches shall know I am he.

EPH. iii, 21. To Him be glory in the Church.

To the congregational Churches of Jesus Christ, particularly that one over which the Holy Ghost hath made me an Overseer: Grace be to you all.

Amen.—I thought it necessary to write to you on some Subjects which are very interesting, and to give you in sundry articles, the particulars of the Faith we profess, as believers in our most adorable Redeemer; with a few agreements which claim the conformity of all those who have given themselves up to the Lord, to walk in all well pleasing to him. I have endeavored to keep close to the sacred pages, which are the grand standard of Faith and Practice, and as many as walk according this rule, peace be on them, and on the whole Israel of God.

The first Subject I wish my brethren well instructed in is the CHURCH of GOD. It must be allowed that the ever blessed God, for the purposes of glorifying his grace, hath chosen a number of persons in Christ—that he gave them to Christ—that the Redeemer accepted them, and delighted in them as his Bride—and though he foreknew their fall in Adam, yet he covenanted with the Father to be their Surety, Righteousness, and Mediator—to deliver them from the hands of their enemies by his precious sacrifice, and in due time to call them by his holy Spirit, to the knowledge of himself; to preserve them in himself till called, and maintain them in the wilderness of this world till their glorification. All these things being planned before

all worlds, in due time the Redeemer came, according to his engagement, and paid down his life for their Justification and Pardon—in consequence of which, Justice being satisfied, the Law honoured, Sinners redeemed, and the Holy Spirit, with all its blessing secured, the Church of God is called, one member after another, and will be so till the whole body is complete: hence the Apostle says, Christ loved the Church, and gave himself for it, that he might save it with the washing of water, by the Word—the glorious Gospel of the blessed God is the means made use of, to bring poor sinners to the knowledge of Jesus—truth having an entrance into the heart, influences all the powers, enlightens the understanding, subdues and reconciles the will, sways the affections, captivates the thoughts, and quickens the conscience. Thus the entrance of God’s word giveth light, and God shines into the heart, sooner or later, to give them the light of the knowledge of the glory of God, in the Person of Jesus. This is attended with love to God, as seen in Jesus—love to the Redeemer, in his Person, Work, and Offices—love to the Holy Spirit, who has done so much for the soul, and stands engaged to do much more. This love is led forth to ministers who are sent of God, especially to those whose ministry is most blessed to us, of whatever denomination they may be. This same principle of love is led forth to those who bear the image of Christ, who are divinely taught, whether they are Children, young Men, or Fathers—for, *he that loveth is born of God*, and knoweth God—Ye are taught of God to love one another—*he that loveth him that begat loveth him also that is begotten*. This fire within catcheth itself wherever it is—in another—thus there is a unity of heart; this unity of heart is attended with a willingness to know, and do the will of God; to worship him according to his declared will, as laid down in the New Testament—to assemble together for Prayer, reading the Word of God, and hearing it faithfully preached by those whom God hath sent. It is to submit to all his Ordinances, *Baptism*, as we are led to see it right, and the *Lord’s Supper*, with the rest of the Lord’s people; and a walking in holy obedience to the revealed will of God. This appears to be the Church of God, which he purchased with his blood; that he always protects, and will maintain as long as the world lasts. This is called his invisible Church (not to himself) but to the work, they being attended with others in the same profession, though not the same *possession*; and making this profession public in their non-conformity to the world, in being called from among them as well as redeemed from among them; in consequence

of these things they are called the visible Church of Christ, which has been called *Catholic*, or *general* Church.

This Church is variously set forth in Scripture, which is worthy our attention, with its present and future glory. Permit me to remark, that many persons suppose a Church to be nothing but a large building: this is not called a Church in Scripture—it does not mean the *Place* but the *People*—the professors of the Gospel, whether called effectually or not, yet walking together in the Ordinances, and appearing to serve the same Master, the whole body is called a Church. There is no pure or perfect Church this side Heaven; in this great House there are not only vessels of gold and silver, but of wood and stone; the wise and foolish virgins must be together till the midnight cry is made—the tares and the wheat must grow together till the harvest—the net will contain good and bad fish, till the final separation takes place.

This Church of Christ is not Parochial, men do not become church Members by living in the Parish, for Jews and Turks may live in the same Parish; nor is it Diocesan, for we never read of more than one Church under one Bishop or Pastor—nor is it Provincial, for we read of more Churches than one in a Province—nor is it National, for we not only read of more than one in a Nation, but of Churches in private houses—nor is a Presbyterian, for we never read of a Church of Presbyters or Elders, no; but only of Presbyters and Elders ordained in Churches; this must plainly prove that Churches existed before the Presbytery or Elders were in them—then it appears plain that the visible Church of Christ is congregational—so the Church of England has justly defined it—“The Church of God is a Congregation of faithful men, in which the pure Word of God is preached and the Sacraments duly administered;” for only the Lord’s faithful people can have fellowship with each other—they must be regenerated by the Spirit, called out of darkness into the kingdom of God’s dear Son—they are called Saints because of their Sanctification, faithful men to God and truth, such as should be saved. They are spiritual men, understanding spiritual things; men of holiness, whose lives and conversation are becoming the Gospel—baptized into Christ, invisibly, by the Spirit, and outwardly by Water, if God is pleased to shew them that it is right, for whatsoever is not of faith is sin. These are the Persons who have a right to chuse their Ministers, their Officers, and to use all the Ordinances and Privileges

granted to the Church by our glorious Lord and Master, Christ, who is the king, head, and saviour of his Elect. It appears the word Church signifies a sacred Assembly or Society, called of God by the Gospel, met together to worship God according to his revealed will. Let this suffice, the Church, in its just and expensive sense, includes *the whole body of the redeemed*.

This Church has appeared in every age of the world; been kept up and supported in a very wonderful manner, which made Solomon exclaim, in raptures of affection, wonder, and delight, *Who is this that cometh up from the Wilderness, like pillars of smoke, perfumed with myrrh and frankincense, with all the powders of the Merchant?*—The History of the Old Testament is but an History of the Church, which, though afflicted, tormented, and tossed with many tempests, yet was miraculously preserved by the Lord Jesus, who never left the world without a witness for himself, nor never will. 'Tis wonderful to trace her rise and prosperity, her persecution and deliverance, till the present hour—and as my dear friends (many of them at least) have but little time to read History, I presume to give them a brief Account of the Church in the Wilderness, for which I am indebted under God, to Historians.

When our Lord made his appearance in the likeness of sinful flesh, he thoroughly purged the floor of his Old Testament Church—he effected a wonderful revolution, set aside every carnal ordinance, and fulfilled all laws, moral and ceremonial. After his death and resurrection he went to glory, that he might fill all things. He endued his Apostles with power from on high—raised up a company of preachers, who were means in the hands of the Spirit, for building Sanctuaries to God. The middle wall of partition was now broken down—the Gentiles were fellow-citizens with the Jews, and both made up one household. We shortly after read of Churches in many parts of the world. For the first fifty years after our Lord's resurrection, the Gospel was most powerfully successful—God sent forth the rod of his strength, and much good was done in the name of the holy child, Jesus.—But Satan roared loudly; the Church was in the Wilderness—and as it had been persecuted as related by the Apostle in the 13th of the *Hebrews*, so it was again—they under the New Testament Dispensation, were persecuted, beaten, sawn asunder—they wandered about in Sheep's and Goat's skins, and hid themselves in dens and caves of the earth. Surely the New Testament Saints are included in that pathetic address, *Oh! thou*

afflicted, tossed with tempest, and not comforted. Errors in doctrine soon appeared, even to the denying of the resurrection of the body—Ordinances were soon corrupted, and worldly-mindedness was prevalent. Persecution wasted the Church of God very early in the year 66; it began by imperial authority. *Nero* having burnt a part of the Roman City, charged it upon the Christians, and enacted laws to destroy them, and multitudes of them were burnt alive in his garden, for nightly illumination: in this Persecution, it is supposed *Paul* and *Peter* suffered death. About the year 72 *Domitian* raised a new Persecution, but he was soon murdered by his wife. About three years after it began, in 105, *Trajan*, the Emperor, raised a third Persecution, which lasted about two years. Then a fourth Persecution by *Adrian*, which lasted ten years—besides, vast numbers of Christians were murdered by the Jewish rebels. For a long time the Church was quiet from outward Persecution, but awfully infested with errors, which became an internal Persecution. About the year 302, the infernal Emperor raised a dreadful one against the Christians; many were scourged to death, had their flesh torn off with red hot pincers, and mangled with broken pots. They were cast to wild beasts, beheaded, crucified, burnt, drowned, torn to pieces between trees, roasted by gentle fires, and some, having holes made in the body, had melted lead poured into their bowels. In Egypt alone, an hundred and forty thousand were cut off by violent deaths, and seven hundred thousand by banishment and hard labour. In every part of the Empire churches were razed to the ground, and the copies of the Scriptures burnt. Now they thought they had utterly abolished the Religion of Jesus; but the vengeance of God followed the hellish tyrant, as it had *Herod, Nero, & Domitian* before. *Cæsar* obliged him to resign his post, and retire to a private life, where he soon ended his days by a draft of poison.

God raised up *Constantine*, the Man Child spoken of in the 12th chapter of *Revelations*; he tolerated the Christians. His colleague revoked it in the East, and, instigated by the Heathen Priests, made war against *Licinius*. The brother-in-law of *Constantine*, enraged at his army being routed, he murdered a multitude of the Priests, who had promised him the victory. He was just going to venture a second battle, when he was smitten with blindness and terrible pain: he poisoned himself, and amidst rage, pain, and despair, acknowledged his trouble the just reward for his cruelty to the Christians. *Licinius* for a time seemed to favor the Christians, yet soon

turned a bitter Persecutor; but *Constantine* being now a Christian, marched a great army against him, and defeated him in three great battles, in the last of which an hundred thousand were slain, *Licinius* taken, and put to death. Thus we see the Bush long burning, and not consumed, because the *Angel of the Covenant* was in it—and this is he that was with the Church in the Wilderness.

The Christians now enjoyed a great calm under the reign of *Constantine* and *Theodosius*; but Satan always took an opportunity to ruin the Church by Heresies when he could not by Persecution. Arianism, and many other errors were propogated, which occasioned dreadful troubles to the Church. *Julian* the Apostate, endeavored once more to extirpate Christianity, but was killed in a Persecution he raised, before he had reigned two years. Errors increased daily. About the beginning of the sixth century the Church seemed more tranquil, but the Devil was incessantly working her ruin by the introduction of Popish errors; ignorance and profaneness was almost universal. The Government was almost one perpetual struggle between the Bishops, which should be the greatest. *Gregory* the Great, by immense superstition, troubled the Church; and her discomfiture was soon universal. This was the case of the Church in the West; while, about this time, *Mahomet* the Arab, took his rise in the East, and propogated his delusion there. Thus the Beast rose about 606, or 666; and now, in another sense, the Church entered into her Wilderness state, the outer Court being given to the Gentiles, to be trodden under foot for forty-two months, or 1260 years. Sad indeed the consequence of the rise of the Man of Sin. For many years worse Persecutions than under the Pagans took place, but God did not leave the World without a Witness for himself. Every now and then the Lord raised up faithful men, who opposed the Pope's Supremacy; particularly *Luther*, in *Germany*—*Zuinglius*, in *Switzerland*, and *Calvin*; in *France*. The christian Religion, as taught by *Luther*, was established in *Demark*, *Sweden*, and *Germany*. The Doctrines taught by *Calvin*, in *Holland*, *Scotland*, *England*, and *Ireland*; but in *Ireland* the Persecution was dreadful indeed, and not much less in *England*. The Popish massacre of about three hundred thousand Protestants in *Ireland*, and the Persecution in *England*, bid fair to abolish the Protestant cause among us. In *France* the Persecution was dreadful—*Lewis* the 13th distressed the Protestants greatly; numbers were barbarously murdered, and several hundred thousand with difficulty

fled to *Holland, England*, and elsewhere. But blessed be God for the glorious Reformation! for a Protestant King and Princes; for the Will of God in our mother Tongue; for Parliaments that secure our Rights; for the clear Preaching of the Gospel, which is our joy, though we have to lament great decays among Churches; a dry, speculative, legal System, in opposition to the pure truth, which is branded with the odious term of Antinomianism; and in the world an infidel spirit of Free-thinking, in opposition to the Word of God. But we are looking to a glorious period, when truth in its native simplicity, shall fly with the rapidity of lightning, and illuminate the World; when *Anti-christ, in the East and West, shall fall, to rise no more*—when *Zion's Watchmen shall see, eye to eye*—when *Jews and Gentiles form one fold*—when *peace and holiness shall be universal*—when *kings shall be nursing fathers to the Church, and the whole earth serve the Lord*! Happy period! the Lord hasten it in his time.

Brethren, we shall soon be done with time, and through rich grace, join the chorus of the skies.—Hold fast the form of sound words: be concerned to feel the power of truth in the heart; keep in the fear of God, obeying his will, walking as he has set forth his mind; looking unto Jesus; praying to be kept in all danger, temptation, persecution, and trial, and so we shall give him glory in the Church below, and in the Church above.—*Now unto him that is able to keep you from falling, and to present you faultless before the presence of his glory—to the only wise God our Saviour, be glory, dominion, and power. Amen.*

The following are the Articles of Faith I read at my Ordination; and are necessary for every Christian to know, feel, and enjoy—they are the Sentiments I preach, and you, as a Church, believe. May we rejoice in the truth, and yield obedience thereto.—

We think it requisite that every Member of the Church should give his or her assent to the annexed

CONFESSION of FAITH.

I. I BELIEVE, that the Scriptures of the Old and New Testament are the word of God, and the only rule of faith and practice.

II. I believe, that there is but One only, living, and true God; that there are three Persons in the Godhead, who are equal in nature, power, and glory; and, that the Son and Holy Ghost, are as truly and properly God, as the Father. These Three divine Persons are distinguished from each other by peculiar relative properties. These Three divine distinct Persons, I profess to reverence, serve, and worship, as the One true God.

III. I believe that before the World began, God did elect a certain number of Mankind unto everlasting life, whom he did predestinate to the adoption of Children, by Jesus Christ, of his own free grace, and according to the good pleasure of his will; that he appointed holiness as the means: and that no one has a right to consider himself as a chosen vessel, till he is effectually called by the grace of God.

IV. I believe, that God made all things in Creation, out of nothing, to display his goodness, wisdom, power, and glory; and, that by the same power, he upholds and governs, rules and directs all things in Heaven and Earth; and, that he displays his sovereignty according to the counsel of his own will, or his eternal plan, formed before all Worlds.

V. I believe, that there is one Mediator between God and Man; the Man, Christ Jesus; that he stood in his mediatorial capacity as our representative and head, in the covenant of eternal redemption and grace; engaged to be all that to his people, they could possibly need in time, and their bliss through eternity.

VI. I believe that God made Man upright; but mutable and liable to fall: that through the influence of Satan, he broke the covenant of works, and fell

from the image of God; that all Mankind sinned in him and fell, with him, as their head and representative; and both him and his posterity became liable to the curse and penalty of a violated law.

VII. I believe, that all Mankind are conceived and born in sin, Children of disobedience, enemies to God, violators of his commands, averse to good, prone to evil, Children of wrath, obnoxious to the justice of God, and the condemnation of his law: and I believe, that no Creature can help or deliver himself, out of that wretched state into which he has fallen. I solemnly believe, that this is the state of all Men by nature.

VIII. I believe, that according to the eternal appointment of God the father, and the Covenant engagements of the dear Redeemer, that in the fulness of time, God sent his Son into the world to redeem fallen Men; that part of the human race, that was given him in eternity; that their redemption was obtained by the shedding of his blood; that this redemption is special and particular, designed only for the elect of God, the Sheep of Christ, who only share the special and peculiar blessings of it. And, in order to accomplish our redemption, I believe, it was necessary that the Redeemer should take upon him our nature, a human body and soul, created and formed by God the Spirit, conceived in the womb of the Virgin Mary, born of a Woman, made under the law, that he might redeem his people from it; work out a righteousness adequate to its demands, make an atonement by suffering the death of the Cross, satisfy divine Justice, glorify all the attributes of Deity, and open a way for the communication of all those blessings, which are needful for the Saints of God, both for time and eternity.

IX. I believe, that the matter of the Sinners' justification before a holy God, is the righteousness of Christ imputed to them; which is, his perfect, spotless obedience to the law, in their room and stead, without the consideration of any works done by them; and, that the full and free pardon of all their sins, past, present, and to come, is only through the blood of Christ, according to the riches of his grace; and, that none can be justified in any other way. This righteousness being seen by the eye of faith, and embraced by the hand of faith, we are manifestly justified and freed from the law; that, being dead wherein we were held, we live to God, and by love serve the Lord, having our fruit unto holiness, and the end eternal life.

X. I believe, that all the objects of eternal love, the subjects of his choice, and the purchase of the Redeemer's blood, are effectually called in one way or other, by the efficacious and irresistible grace of God the divine Spirit; and not by an act of Man's free will and power. I believe they are washed, justified, and sanctified, in the name and by God the Spirit, in some part of their lives.

XI. I believe, that all saints are kept by the mighty power of God, through faith, to eternal Salvation; and that as sure as they are called, justified, and sanctified, they will infallibly persevere; because of the perpetuity of God's love, the stability of his covenant, and his faithfulness to his absolute promises.

XII. I believe, that the Church of Christ consists of true believers in his name; that these are his mystical body, of which, he is the only head, and there is no other: and that all the Children of God derive spiritual life from him, by virtue of union to him; that he is our life; and in consequence of that, we are now quickened by his life-giving power in conversion; our bodies shall be quickened in the last day, and all Believers shall enjoy eternal life, in glory for ever.

XIII. I believe, that in the new testament Church of Christ, there are two Sacraments: Baptism, and the Supper of the Lord. I believe, Baptism to be an outward and visible sign; first, of the sufferings, death, burial, and resurrection of our Lord Jesus Christ; secondly, of an inward and spiritual operation of the Holy Ghost, upon the hearts of believers; and is a grand emblem of a death unto sin, and a new birth unto righteousness; for being by nature the children of wrath, we are by regeneration, manifested to be children of grace. I believe, that only those who profess the name of Jesus, have any right thereto. That it should be administered to Adults alone, in the name of the adorable Trinity; and, that it is to be performed by immersion—but wish to exercise the most unbounded charity to all who differ from us in this particular. I believe, that the Lord's Supper was instituted the night on which he was betrayed, to represent his sufferings and death; and is to be attended to by all Believers, until his second coming.

XIV. I believe, that it is the duty of every Christian to obey the laws of their Country; not to speak evil of Dignities; but, to pray for the King, his

Family, and the Government under which we live; to study to be quiet, peaceable, and submissive, according to the laws of Jesus Christ, which is our rule of conduct: and, who has said, “Render unto Cæsar, the things which are his;” and by his holy Apostles has commanded “That every Soul should be subject to the higher powers; that we should honor all Men, love the Brotherhood, fear God, honor the King.”

XV. I believe, that it is the duty of all Believers, to take the commands of our Lord and Saviour Jesus Christ, as their rule of conduct; that, while they are relying on his Righteousness, for justification; on his Blood, for pardon; and, on the Spirit, for internal sanctification; they, from a principal of love shed abroad in their hearts, are made willing to obey his laws, as King in Mount Zion: and, that his commandments are the believer’s rule of outward conduct; that it is their duty to stand fast in one Spirit, with one mind, striving together for the faith of the gospel: that it is their duty to walk in wisdom, to them that are without; to exercise a conscience void of offence towards God and Man, by living soberly, righteously, and godly in this present world: that it is their duty to walk with each other in all humility and brotherly love; to watch over each other’s conversation; to stir up one another to love and to good works; not forsaking the assembling of ourselves together, as we have opportunity; to worship God, according to his revealed will; and, when the case requires, to warn, rebuke, and admonish one another, according to the rules of the gospel: and that it is our duty to sympathize with each other, to bear with one another’s weaknesses, failings, and infirmities; and, particularly to pray for one another. All these duties we are bound to perform, and every other law of Christ’s spiritual house, through the gracious influence of a Spirit of love, of power, and of a sound mind; ever remembering, that we are to obey the laws of our Sovereign, as King, on his holy hill of Zion.

XVI. I believe, that all the Ordinances of divine appointment ought to be attended unto, by all that profess their faith in, and love to our Lord Jesus Christ, as the head of his Church; hearing the Word, public Prayer, Baptism, and the Lord’s Supper: singing of Psalms, Hymns, and Spiritual Songs, vocally; this is an ordinance of the gospel, to be performed by Believers; but, as to time, place, and manner, every one ought to be left to their liberty in using it.

XVII. I believe, that there will be a Resurrection, both of the just and unjust; and that Christ will come a second time to judge both quick and dead; when he will take vengeance on the wicked, and introduce his own People into his kingdom and glory, where they shall be for ever with him; and, then shall the mediatorial kingdom be delivered up to the Father, by the Redeemer; the mystery of God be finished: Heaven will be the Saints final home; and, God, Father, Son, and Spirit, be all in all, for ever and ever.

XVIII. I believe, that the felicity of the Saints will be eternal; and I as firmly believe, such will be the eternity of misery; unless, the never-dying worm dies, and this unquenchable fire goes out; which will not, cannot be; for the mouth of the Lord hath spoken it.

These Sentiments we are bound to acknowledge, as a Church.—We wish in all things to adorn these Doctrines; and having been called out of the world, to the knowledge of the truth, *experimentally*—in that hope, and through divine grace, we have given up ourselves to God—to walk in his ways, as laid down in that part of his holy word which respects the *New Testament Church*. We therefore enter into covenant with each other, and pray for grace to keep the following scriptural RULES.

THE MEMBERS' COVENANT.

JER. l. 5. Come, let us join ourselves to the Lord, in a perpetual Covenant that shall not be forgotten.

ACTS ii, 2. And they continued stedfastly in the Apostles Doctrine, and in fellowship.

LUKE xxiv, 15. And it came to pass that while they communed together, and reasoned, Jesus himself drew near, and went with them.

WE AGREE,

1.—WITH regard to the *Minister*—that as long as God is pleased to make him useful to our souls, and we consider him as sent of God—we will diligently attend upon his Ministry—cheerfully submit to and readily obey all the Ordinances he administers—agreeable to the written word—Heb. xiii, 7. *Remember them that have the rule over you, who have spoken to you the Word of God.* We further agree to make prayer and supplication for him, to watch his conversation, and follow him as far as he follows Christ. That we will esteem him, reverence, and obey him in the Lord—agreeable to 1 Thess. v, 13. *And we beseech you, Brethren to know them which labour among you, and are over you in the Lord, and admonish you—and to esteem them very highly in love, for their Works sake. Brethren, pray for us. Prayer was made without ceasing to God for him—Whose faith follow, considering the end of their conversion.*—And we agree, according to our circumstances, by the administration of earthly things, to support and maintain him, agreeable to 1 Cor. xi. *If we have sown unto you in spiritual things, is it a great thing if we should reap your carnal things? Even so hath the Lord appointed.*—We agree likewise to abide by him in all trials and persecutions—that we will encourage him, strengthen his hands, and

speaking kindly of him—avoiding all bitterness of spirit, tattling and gossiping about him, as contrary to the Gospel.

2.—We agree to receive and esteem all *Officers* in the Church, that have been appointed by the Church, whose faith and practice is conformable to the written word. That we will speak kindly of them, receive reproof from them when necessary, and make known all cases of distress, spiritual or temporal, in the Church, to them—while we have reason to believe they answer the spiritual character of a Deacon, as laid down in 1 Tim. 3rd Chapter.

3.—We agree, through grace, to be found in the use of all appointed means, public and private, and on special occasions, when notified by the Minister, as in Acts xiv, 2. *When they were come, and had gathered the Church together.—Forsake not the assembling yourselves together, as the manner of some is.—Where two or three are gathered together, there am I in the midst. Lo, I am with you always.*

4.—As Members of the same Church, we will endeavour to cultivate an affectionate and sincere love, without dissimulation, towards one another—like that which Christ bears to his Church; and studiously avoid all occasion of division among the members—such as hard speeches, cruel and unjust remarks, disdainful looks, reproaches, slanders, and all causeless divisions in judgment concerning spiritual things. But that we will watch and pray against these things, as injurious to the cause of Christ; but endeavor to maintain a oneness of mind and consent of judgment, to every grand truth, and a uniformity of practice.—*Ye yourselves are taught of God to love one another.—Be kindly affectioned one towards another. By this shall all men know that ye are my disciples, if ye love one another.*

5.—We mutually agree to pray for the prosperity of the kingdom of Christ, particularly for that part to which we belong—that body of christians which we commune with. This we will do through grace, constantly, cheerfully, and affectionately, publicly, and more frequently in private—especially for the most tried, afflicted, and poor members. *Pray ye for the peace of Jerusalem—they shall prosper that love her. Continuing constant in prayer.*

6.—That, as a Church, we will, as much as possible, be separate from the World, its customs, maxims, pursuits, & worship. Pray against a worldly spirit, either of levity or sullenness, covetous of oppressive, in dealing with others.—*Come out from among them, and be ye separate, saith the Lord.*

7.—We agree to study each others spiritual benefit, and take every opportunity, for the communion of Saints, to impart what light or enjoyments, trials, and mercies, sorrows and deliverances. To avoid all frothy, light, or vain conversation, as not becoming a Church of Christ. *Then they that feared the Lord spake often one to another. Let your speech be always with grace. Wherefore comfort one another, and edify one another, as also ye do.*

8.—We will endeavour to bear with each others infirmities, weakness, and failings, in meekness, patience, and pity—render them what assistance we can, by prayer, advice, and kindness; not approving their errors, but recommending them to the Lord, and forgiving every offence done against us, when we believe such an offender is sorry, and will acknowledge his sin. *Be ye kind to one to another—tender hearted. If thy brother repent forgive him. We that are strong ought to bear the infirmities of the weak. Charity suffereth long, and is kind. If any man have a quarrel against any, even as Christ forgave you, so also do ye.*

9.—We agree to sympathize with each other in the calamities and trials that may befall us—either affliction of body, unjust reproach, real falls, family afflictions, or temptation and soul troubles. *Remember them that are in bonds, as bound with them; and those who suffer adversity. If one member suffers all the members suffer with it. Bear ye one anothers burdens. Ye ought to support the weak.*

10.—We agree to contribute to the real necessities of those who are poor—in things temporal, according to every one's ability. *Let us do good to all men, especially the household of faith. And if thy brother be waxen poor and fallen into decay with thee, thou shall relieve him. Distributing to the necessity of the saints, given to hospitality—for God loveth a cheerful giver.*

11.—We mutually agree to watch over each other for good—to comfort the feeble-minded, to warn the unruly, and to reprove in faithfulness, wisdom, moderation, and kindness, what we see amiss in each other—to endeavor to

restore a fallen Brother—to seek consolation for him by prayer and the word; but if persisting in an evil cause, acquaint the Officers of the Church, that they may take up the cause.—*Brethren, if any of you do err from the faith, and one convert (or restore) him, let him know, that he which converteth a sinner from the error of his way, shall save a soul from death. —Yet count him not an enemy, but admonish him as a Brother. He that being often reprov'd, hardeneth his neck, shall be destroyed without a remedy. Let us consider one another.*

12.—We hope, through grace, to walk in all holiness of life, to the glory of the Gospel, the edification of the Church, and conviction to them that are without—looking unto Jesus, depending on his unmerited favour, rejoicing in his Person and Work, and lodging for the happy time, when we shall join the Church triumphant in heaven.—*Let your light so shine. Having these promises, let us cleanse ourselves.—See that ye walk circumspectly.*

And now, Brethren, I commend you to God, and to the word of his grace, which is able to build you up, and to give you an inheritance among them that are sanctified, by faith in Christ Jesus. *Amen.*

FINIS.

*** END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE NATURE OF
A GOSPEL CHURCH ***

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